

Christiaan Verhoef

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Airbus R&T / mipublic.nl

Innovation Manager / Head of Tech Hub Netherlands

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Dear team,

What I do is build the rooms where the ideas happen. Not the ideas themselves -- the structures, the teams, the external networks, and the operating rhythms that make a small innovation group function like it belongs inside a large institution while still moving like it doesn't. I have done this at Windesheim University (Spark! Living Lab, 2020 to present), at Aeres Hogeschool (innovation hub, 10 student projects incubated, two became companies), and in parallel as co-founder of Tonomy Foundation, where I built a European partner network and product ecosystem from zero. The Airbus Tech Hub at 8 FTE is structurally comparable to all three. That is not a stretch. That is the job I have been doing.

The ecosystem mandate specifically is where I think I can add the most. The Tech Hub's value to Airbus depends on the quality of its connections to the Dutch innovation ecosystem -- to universities, research institutes, funding bodies, startups, and government programmes. I have built those kinds of networks in supply chain, sustainability, and digital identity. The pattern for how you build them -- who you need in the room, what you offer them, what governance makes it last -- is the same regardless of sector. And with Airbus's brand behind the role, the access is there from day one. What I add is the structure and the momentum.

One gap to name directly: I do not come with existing Dutch aerospace sector networks. My background is in supply chain innovation, sustainability, and digital infrastructure. For a permanent head of the Hub, this would matter more. For an interim mandate where the primary task is building and running a team while expanding the ecosystem, the ability to enter a new sector quickly and build from scratch is arguably more relevant than pre-existing contacts. My track record on that is solid -- I have done it in every engagement I have taken on.

A note on the KONGSBERG years, because it speaks to the Airbus context: I spent two years as a solo field deployment engineer in oil and gas, in regulated environments with no internet access and no one to call. The combination of strict process discipline in safety-critical settings with initiative when the procedure runs out is something I carry into every role. In a regulated corporate like Airbus, that combination -- not just entrepreneurial energy, but entrepreneurial energy that understands why the rules exist -- is what makes innovation labs actually work rather than fight the institution.

I am available ZZP, immediately, and Leiden is commutable from Baarn. I am happy to discuss rate, scope, and the timing question around the assignment start date in a conversation.

With best regards,

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